Introduction

> *In March 2016, I wrote the following column for* Domain, *which went viral and sparked a national conversation about how aspiring first home buyers handle money. At the heart of the debate was the pursuit of the Great Australian Dream of home ownership by a generation up against a property price boom.*

I am 33 and my parents give me pocket money.

My mum and dad pass on a few hundred dollars every fortnight from my salary.

It's my severe first home savings plan, as property prices rise in suburbs I would have once considered affordable.

My wages are paid into an account controlled by my parents and, from that, they hand me $400 a fortnight to live on.

I have deprived myself of financial freedom to save for a home after years of unbridled spending. It's the only way I know how.

By choice, I am not aware of the bank account number or passwords, so there is no temptation – or ability – to get my hands on my money, beyond what is rationed to me.

I am a former fashion writer and I have an extravagant wardrobe of clothes, shoes and bags. The breakdown of my once soaring credit card bill read like the index of a high-end fashion magazine.

But I don't have the most important asset: a property. And when I get dressed in the morning, I am confronted by material evidence of my own excess.

No amount of Chanel will keep anyone warm at night or financially afloat in old age, no matter how much glossy magazines swear that luxury garb is an 'investment'.

So I have put a strategy in place to save hard for my first home.

Since August 2015, every fortnightly payday my parents have given me $400 of what I call 'wriggle room money' – a portion of what's left over